

BHASKAR PAUL



NIGHT'S END: The Inorbit mall from where Adnan took his last drive (above); A family picture of Patrawala whether she had any role in the crime. "There is no involvement of any girl in the murder," says senior police inspector Kiran Sonone, while hinting that Angel could be a man masquerading as a girl on the website.

Meanwhile, Patrawala's family has blamed the media for their son's death. "Had the media restrained itself by not throwing out details of the investigations, my son would have been alive," laments Patrawala's mother Lubna. Even before the police could locate the body, television channels had begun debating on the need to ban networking sites like Orkut.

However, the murder has added a new dimension to the incidents involving youngsters on the loose. As an average school student, Patrawala enjoyed spending time and money on his friends. According to his relatives, he had been driving a Mercedes since the age of 12 and would frequently indulge in drinking. On an average, he spent Rs 5,000 to Rs 10,000 on gaming and partying, daily. His Orkut profile bears a photograph of him holding an alcoholic beverage and talking about driving his car at 180 kmph speed.

His mother is, however, defensive. "He was never a reckless driver, so what if he drove at a young age," she says. But it was the company his

SECONDS TO DEATH

- **AUGUST 18, 11 p.m.:** Patrawala receives a call from his friends to reach Inorbit mall.
- **AUGUST 19, 1.30 a.m.:** He informs his mother that he was going to meet his friends and would return only the next morning.
- **AUGUST 19, 8.30 a.m.:** The kidnapers use Patrawala's phone to make a ransom call, demanding Rs 2 crore from his father.



- **AUGUST 19, 1.30 p.m.:** Patrawala calls up home to say he is fine.
- **AUGUST 19, 8 p.m.:** News channels begin to flash news of Patrawala being kidnapped.
- **AUGUST 19, 9.30 p.m.:** The kidnapers panic. Patrawala is murdered.
- **AUGUST 20, 2007, 3 p.m.:** After confirming their involvement, the police arrests the trio.

son kept that gave her sleepless nights. "She often asked his father to keep a check on him, but Adnan was always pampered by his father," says a relative. He adds that the same friends who murdered him had stolen his mobile phone a few months ago. Though Patrawala knew about the theft, he continued his friendship with the trio.

According to the police, the teenagers were lured by the easy money that Patrawala showered on them. This is what made them kidnap and finally murder the boy. Nair, an ex-BPO employee lived alone as a paying guest in Malad. He was planning to flee to Dubai, where his mother works as a nurse. The police has confirmed that Nair was the mastermind behind the plan and it was he who had roped in the other two accomplices. Bhatt, whose father is a music organiser of an orchestra party, was learning music and Ambavat was a student at the Thakur College in Kandivli. His father owns a small advertising agency. The trio had a modest background and thrived on the money spent by Patrawala.

"Nair in his statement has said that they had tried to kidnap Patrawala sometime back, but the plan did not work. They had been planning this kidnapping for the last 10 days," says the police. They are now questioning 30 of Patrawala's friends to get further insight in the case.

But Bhatt's father, Arun, claims his son has been falsely implicated in the kidnapping. "My son and I have been cooperating with the police since the time the murder took place. How could he have committed the crime if he was with the police?", he asks. He further adds that his son had been framed by two of his friends, Adil and Afreen, who led the police to their house. "Adil and Afreen didn't get along with Ayush very well. They made the police believe that just because he spent time with Patrawala, he was the one who kidnapped him," he says.

So, while the police is still searching the leftover pieces of the puzzle, the gruesome murder by those whom Patrawala called "buddies" is a stigma on the dangerous world of 'fun and friends'.